SAMPLE

The Conflicted Maiden

The Personality Torn Between Duty and Desire

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Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1

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Introduction

You know this person, or you are this person. The record begins with its most divided exhibit: the surgeon whose violin case goes to work with him — the case that has ridden under his desk for twenty years, through fellowship and marriage and head of department — and the file's found line, spoken once at a retirement dinner by the one colleague who knew: *he was never a surgeon who played; he was two careers hiding inside one suit*; the eldest daughter who runs the family firm in the daylight — the fourth generation of the name on the letterhead, the sacrifices repaid, the town's respect worn like a uniform — and who keeps, across the river under a name nobody at the firm knows, the studio where the heart's whole alphabet lives — the canvases her family has never seen and the record's plain finding, entered in the ink the whole book lives in: *both loves are real; both are fed; neither has ever been told about the other*; and the friendship the file cannot close — the one from the old life, the music life, who asked after a decade of Saturdays-with-excuses what was actually happening, and received the type's whole signature in six words: *I couldn't choose, so I kept both* — and the record's quiet correction, which the whole file turns on: *the Maiden chose every day for twenty years; the only choice never made was the one that counts.*

This is a case file on the Conflicted Maiden: the personality torn between duty and desire.

The founding scene is the two-masted self — and the file marks what makes it the catalog's most expensive origin: two loves were installed in one child, and the child was never asked to pick — the family's expectation, installed with love and sacrifice and the weight of a name, and the heart's own signal, arriving early and unmistakably, lit from the inside — the recital and the report card, the shop and the stage, the pews and the page — both honored, both fed, both *mutually exclusive as futures* — and the child, standing at the intersection of two inheritances, drew the constitution the whole life runs on: *I will never make you choose — I will pay both altars — and I will never tell either altar about the other* — and the engine that follows is the catalog's most exhausting: the split maintained at full cost — neither side allowed to win, neither side allowed to lose — excellence run in two currencies, the secret kept like a second passport, the self distributed like an inheritance — and the signature the world sees: the person who is *excellent in both worlds and exhausted in neither's language* — because each world reads the tiredness as belonging to somewhere else.

But the flaw is built into the same engine, and the ledger audits it in the same ink: a self that never answers to itself is not a neutral arrangement — it is a *tie*

— and a tie, in the record's arithmetic, pays nobody: the years spent funding both masters are the years neither master was fully served, the middle ground of belonging nowhere fully is the most expensive ground in this catalog, and the record's central finding, uniform across every case: the split does not hold the two loves apart; it holds the *self* apart — and the person standing in the middle of two excellent half-lives is the only person in the file who never once appeared *whole* in either of them.

And the growth: the integration — and the file is precise, because this is the growth the type fears more than losing either altar: not the amputation of a love, but the *honesty* of both — the Maiden's discovery that both loves can be kept *openly*, in one life, under one signature, and that the load- bearing question — which altar actually holds you up, when both are watching and neither approves — has an answer, and the answer, the record has learned, is older than the first prayer; and the growth's central turn: the Maiden keeps both loves — they were always real, always earned — and loses the only thing the split ever actually protected: the *secret*, the half-membership, the exhausting privilege of never being fully known — and gains the one thing neither altar could ever grant: a self that answers to itself.

If you are this type, the book's wager is exact: you are the most capable person in both of your rooms, and the record holds the proof — the two resumes, the two fluencies, the twenty years of double excellence — and the file's question, kept waiting through ten chapters and put to you here so you can face standing in it: *when both altars were fed, who was fed?* — because the record's answer, in every case, is the same quiet arithmetic: everything was paid, and the payer was you — and the file's plainest line on the type: *you did not fail to choose; you chose not to, and the difference decided the decades.* If you love one, your instruction is precise and counterintuitive: do not praise the balance — the balance is the wound's name; the world calls it range — and do not pick an altar for them; the type has survived everyone's choosing for a lifetime; the instruction that works, and the record has tested it: *ask for the whole self* — one dinner, one calendar, one name in both rooms — because the Maiden does not need help maintaining anything; the Maiden needs one person who refuses to be given half, and stands there, warmly, until the two lives are introduced — to you, and to each other.

Turn the page. The Maiden is still out there — in the firm with the studio across the river, in the clinic with the case under the desk, in the two friend-groups who have never met — and the file's promise is the record's plainest: And one note before the record is opened to the public: this is the volume in the library where the case arrives with *two addresses* — and the finding, entered first so the reader can watch for it in every chapter ahead: the Conflicted Maiden is

not a weak person who cannot choose — the Conflicted Maiden is a *strong* person who was handed two loves and told, by a house that could not hold both, that the loves were enemies — and the question the whole book turns on, asked gently, of anyone who has kept two calendars, two wardrobes, two selves, for longer than they can remember: what was the split protecting — and what would one table, with both of its loves seated at it, actually cost?

The dossier's whole wager, held plainly: the cost is not what you think — the table is not the surrender of a room; the table is the first room the whole self has ever been allowed to eat in.

the two loves were always the gift; the *split* was the wound; and the life, once it answers to itself, becomes what it always looked like from the outside and never was: not a compromise stretched across two altars — one whole self, at one table, that both of its loves are allowed to sit at.

Chapter 1: The Signature — the Conflicted Maiden at a Glance

Before anyone speaks, the room receives a person who belongs to it precisely — and slightly less than fully. The Conflicted Maiden arrives with warmth, reads the gathering in one pass, and takes their place in it as though the place had been assigned — but there is a rhythm to their presence, an arrival-and-departure cadence, the bearing of someone who is *here* and also *booked*: the glance at the door between stories, the phone turned face-down with the screen's light leaking around its edges, the goodbye said five minutes before anyone else has begun to think of leaving — *I have an early morning*, the file's most frequent sentence, and it is never a lie, and it is never the whole truth either. Sharper under observation: the departure is not boredom; it is the other life, waiting, with its own lamplight.

The manner carries a doubleness that the practiced eye can catch and the unpracticed eye only feels: fluency in the room's language, its jokes, its reference points — and a fraction of a second's *translation lag*, the tiny pause of a person who is always switching registers, the way bilingual speakers carry both grammars behind one voice. The Maiden knows this room; the Maiden is also always knowing another room; and the hands show it — the doctor's hands that remember the instrument; the manager's phone that holds the group chat from the world the firm has never heard of. Sharper under observation: ask them what they do, and the answer comes polished and complete — and ask what they love, and the answer comes a half-beat late, with a small inward look, as though the truth had to be checked at the border

first.

And underneath the competence runs the tell the type's loved ones all report and none can name at first: a watchfulness about *being known* — the conversational habit of giving, generously, everything except the thing that would let one world see into the other — the family stories withheld at the studio, the studio stories withheld at the table, until the withholding itself is the type's accent. Sharper under observation: the Maiden is the most trustworthy person in the file with everyone's secrets and the last person in the file to trust anyone with their own.

The file holds two tellings of the origin, and each one is true, and they converge on the same child.

In the first version, the household was an altar: the family's expectation installed early and installed with love — the business built by a grandfather's hands, or the profession carried like a faith, or simply the enormous felt weight of sacrifice repaid in obedience — and the child was the one who *could carry it*: bright enough, responsible enough, loved enough to understand what was being asked. The report cards went on the refrigerator; the relatives said *the one who'll take over*; the child said the sentence back, because it was true in the room where it was said.

In the second version, the other love arrived on its own, the way the heart's signals do: early, unmistakably, and without anyone's permission — the instrument at seven, the page at nine, the stage, the sketchbook, the sea — the thing the child did when no one was asking them to do anything, the activity that made time go strange and whole, the love that required no altar because it made its own fire.

And the origin moment, where the versions converge, is always a night, and always the same night in every case: the night the child discovered that both loves could be *kept* — the homework for the family's dream done at the desk until ten, the heart's practice done in secret until midnight — and the discovery, filed as triumph and priced later as constitution: *I don't have to choose; I can pay both altars; nobody is ever going to lose* — and the quiet contract the child signed in that midnight, which the whole adult life executes: *both loves honored, both fed, neither told about the other, and the choosing — never.* The record's correction is entered on the contract itself: a self that is never asked to choose will spend its life not-choosing, and the deferral, repeated daily for decades, is itself the choice — made by default, at twelve years old, in the dark, by a child who was solving for *nobody gets hurt*.

The album opens the way every one of these albums opens: the photos are

good, and the child is smiling in all of them. The award ceremony — the certificate, the proud row of relatives, the handshake, the child in the family's Sunday clothes, wearing the family's future like a blazer cut slightly large. The recital, the exhibition, the tournament — the heart's world in its own Sunday clothes, the child lit from the inside, and the family in the audience, applauding, filing it under *talent*, the way one files a nice hobby. Two sets of photographs, both genuine, both kept — sometimes in the same drawer, sometimes, the file notes, in two different houses.

The album's most telling photo is the one nobody asks to see: the doorway picture — the child caught, at some family gathering, standing in the threshold between two lit rooms, half in each, turning toward whichever room called their name last — the posture the whole life would keep: the self positioned at the border, belonging to whichever summons arrives, and to neither room's interior, where people are casually, fully *home*.

And the album ends on the closer the series knows is coming: the child already the adult — the twelve-year-old at midnight with two lives on the desk and the light in the eyes of someone who has just discovered an inexhaustible fuel — the moment the exhaustion was installed as stamina, the deferral installed as strategy, and the secret installed as the self's only private property. The child looks into the camera of that midnight and says, without words, the whole constitution: *I can keep everything.* The album, gently, disagrees: the child kept everything — and the child was the first thing *held*.

Energy: doubled and divided — enough voltage for two lives, wired to spend it as two half-lives; the type's tiredness is legendary at both tables and legible at neither.

Ambition: real in both directions and final in neither; the type takes every prize short of the crown, because crowns require a throne, and a throne is an address.

Vanity structure: being the good one at both tables — the pride is not in winning either world but in *never having failed either*, the flawless attendance at two churches.

Loyalty: total, and distributed — the type keeps every vow ever made, to both masters, and the record's dry note: the only person never given a vow was the self.

Weakness: the unmade choice — the fatal fluency in *both*, the ability to fund two lives until the decade where the funding comes due.

Unspoken need: to be allowed one self — one table, one name, one

continuous life that does not require the border crossing; the need the type guards like a secret, because naming it out loud would indict both altars, and the type has promised to indict neither.

At a party. The Maiden is excellent at parties — both kinds: the duty world's dinner and the heart world's late table. Warm, quick, fluent, and *timed* — there is always a second event, real or invented, on the far side of the goodbye; and the file's sharp detail: at each party the type speaks freely about everything except the party they attended last week, in the other life, which was better.

In a new job. Brilliant, fast, over-qualified, and mysteriously *provisional* — the contract signed with a clause only the type can read. The new employer gets excellence; the new employer does not get the future, because the future is a joint account held in another world — and the type's one predictable fault line: the promotion that would demand the whole self, the partnership track, the relocation, the role that eats evenings — declined, gracefully, with reasons that are all true and none complete.

Under sudden pressure. Splendid — the one situation where the type is briefly *whole*: crisis collapses the split, one self fronts the emergency, and the Maiden performs with a clarity that both worlds admire and neither can account for. The record's note: this is why the type is beloved on every team — and why the type sometimes, the file's most delicate finding, *waits for the crisis*, the only door it knows to its own single-mindedness.

In a boring meeting. The body attends; the other life writes its letters behind the eyes — the set list rehearsed, the chapter drafted, the itinerary built — and the daydream is not escape but *bookkeeping*, the constant silent maintenance of the world this room is not. The tell: the pen moves, and what it draws belongs to the other country.

On holiday. Planned as one self, packed for two — the business trip with the instrument in the luggage, the family holiday with the laptop and the studio hours quietly claimed; the vacation, the file finds, is the split's most expensive stage, because the two worlds' costs are paid in the same week, and the type returns from rest *owing* rest.

The *Yearning Lover* (Volume 18) is the nearest neighbor on the desire side, and the border is thin: both types carry a great want. But the Lover's want has no counterweight — the Lover *crosses* toward the heart's world, pays for it in renunciation and risk, and has one continuous, if burning, life; the Conflicted Maiden lives *astride* the border, pays both tolls, and has never once crossed. The test: the Lover has stories of what the love cost them in the duty world's currency; the Maiden has no such stories — the Maiden's currency was never

spent, only *divided*.

The *Burdened Ruler* (Volume 14) is the nearest neighbor on the duty side, and the confusion is the mirror: both types carry an inheritance. But the Ruler *chose* — early, gravely, with the whole self, paying the heart's world in deliberate renunciation; the Ruler is sad and *whole*; the Maiden is thriving and *split*. The test: ask about the sacrifice. The Ruler can name it and date it. The Maiden will change the subject to logistics.

The *Frozen Maiden* (Volume 46) shares the name and the founding weather, and the hinge is the sharpest in this chapter: both types survived a childhood by managing the inner life at the border — the Frozen Maiden by *extinguishing* the signal (the feelings frozen so the child could endure), the Conflicted Maiden by *splitting* it (both signals kept lit, in separate rooms). The test in one image: the Frozen Maiden flies one flag at half-mast; the Conflicted Maiden flies two at full — and only the second type is exhausted. Sharper than the neighbors, and finally than the test: whichever room you put the Conflicted Maiden in, they are the most capable person present — and the only person in the room who lives somewhere else; that is the glance, that is the lag, that is the door.

The census keeps one field check at the chapter's close, and the file prints it because it separates the Maiden from every neighbor in a single question: *what did you love first?* Every subject in the record is asked the inventory questions — the resume, the passions, the proud of, the regretted — and most types answer in one currency, the same country visible from every angle of the life. The Conflicted Maiden's answers, run across the interviews, are the catalog's only *bilingual* data set: two answers to everything, two resumes, two proud-ofs — and the fieldworkers' finding, logged with the care this gallery reserves for its quietest discoveries: the answers are not evasive and not humble.

They are *patrolled* — each answer checked, at the border, for what it would reveal about the other country before it is released — and the half-second lag the room reads as thoughtfulness is, under the fieldworkers' clock, the customs clearance itself, running in real time. And the diagnostic's second half, the one the record holds up for any reader sorting a person in their life tonight: ask what they love, and then ask *what did you love first* — because the record's Maidens, uniformly fluent about both countries, go quiet at the word *first*: the first love is the border's oldest crossing, the one the treaty sealed before the child could read, and the silence around it is not confusion.

It is a citizen, consulting the constitution, at a question the constitution was written to prevent. The type's loved ones, the file notes in closing, almost

never need the census. They feel the lag at the table. This passage is only here to tell them what the lag is: not distraction, not boredom, not the other person — the *other country*, and the border, and the self, standing in it, both flags flying, waiting for the one question that was never allowed in either land: *who else is at this table?*

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